Q+A

THE ENCHANTER OF LANDOUR

Ruskin Bond, national treasure and one of India's most beloved authors, is back with *The Enchanted Cottage*, a short book that reads like a greatest hits package

Q. The role of the owl in this book is fascinating. Readers may remember your poem 'The Owl'. Could you tell us more about the bird's role here?
I have a soft corner for owls. In *The Enchanted Cottage*, I felt that the owl and the crow would be a good way to get into the story. Of course, there's a lot of superstition around owls, but they're useful, they keep the rat population down. On the one hand, the owl is considered wise in folklore but in India, we also often call a foolish person '*ullu*'.

Q. About the character David Fennimore, there's this sense that for the hill people, he represents every plains-dweller who comes up for a vacation, screws up their lives and hightails it out of the place...
You're right, there's a bit of that with Fennimore, and that also explains why the locals in this book have built a superstition around him. But Fennimore is also a dream-creation. I have this habit of noting down my more interesting dreams in a journal so that I can use them in stories later. And the character of Fennimore was one such thing.

Q. While reading the book, you almost feel like you're in the middle of a Gothic mystery, where the old manor or country house is also a character...
The story is based on Maplewood Cottage, where I lived when I first came to these parts. It was right next to a forest and close to a stream. Sadly, the cottage isn't there anymore: along came the PWD and built a road through the property, taking a part of the forest as well.

Q. There are references to *Walden* and *Robinson Crusoe* in this book: were these 'man-isolated-amidst-nature' texts on your mind lately?
I actually had a copy of *Walden* with me when I lived at Maplewood. Also, Richard Jeffries' *The Story of My Heart*, which had a lot of nature passages. There aren't too many books of this kind, so the few good ones become all the more important.

with Aditya Mani Jha



M ZHAZO